

Encoding Strategy

Field	Method used	Why this method	Alternative avoided
Gender, Diabetic, Smoker	Label encoding (0/1)	Only two possible values each, so there's no risk of implying a false order or ranking	One-hot encoding — unnecessary here, adds columns for no benefit
Region	One-hot encoding, one category dropped	Four categories with no natural order — label encoding would falsely imply Northeast < Northwest < Southeast < Southwest	Label encoding — would mislead any model that treats numbers as ordered